



Overtourism

Can a place be loved to death?

The world has never traveled more. For some of its most beloved places, that is precisely the trouble.



Listen to the article

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Thousands of tourists crowd the streets and beach in Positano, Italy.

WARM-UP

Discuss the questions with a partner.

1. Think of a place you love that has become popular. Has its popularity improved it or diminished it?
2. Is there a real difference between a “tourist” and a “traveler”, or is it a distinction we make to feel better about ourselves?

When Barcelona residents took water pistols to the streets, spraying bewildered visitors at sidewalk cafés, the protest looked playful. Its message was not. “Tourists go home,” read the banners, in a city whose economy leans heavily on the very people being soaked. It exposed an uncomfortable truth: some of the world’s most admired places have become **victims of their own success**. The harder question is who, exactly, the victims are.

The word “overtourism” suggests a simple problem of numbers, but numbers alone explain surprisingly little. What matters more is concentration, and who **bears the brunt** of it. The profits flow largely to airlines, hotel groups, and investors, while the costs—noise, congestion, soaring rents—fall on whoever happens to live nearby. As short-term rentals replace long-term tenants, historic centers can be quietly **hollowed out**, their bakeries and schools giving way to souvenir shops and luggage lockers.

Venice is the starkest example. Its historic center, home to fewer than 50,000 people, can receive twice that number of visitors on a single busy day. Venice has introduced an entry fee for some day-trippers, though critics argue a small charge is unlikely to deter anyone who has crossed an ocean. Amsterdam has restricted new hotels; on Mount Everest, climbers have queued for hours below the summit.

Yet every remedy involves **trade-offs**. Fees and caps may preserve a city’s character while turning it into a playground for the wealthy. Steering visitors toward lesser-known towns may simply spread the damage more thinly. Some argue the real task is to **reconcile** residents and visitors rather than choose between them. Whether that is achievable, or merely a comforting phrase, is far from clear.

If a city is shaped by everyone who passes through it, who should decide its future?

VOCABULARY

A. Match the expressions (1–5) with their meanings (A–E).

- | | | |
|--------------------------------|-------|--|
| 1. a victim of its own success | _____ | A. to suffer the worst of it |
| 2. bear the brunt of | _____ | B. a gain that involves a loss |
| 3. hollow out | _____ | C. to make conflicting aims fit |
| 4. trade-off | _____ | D. hurt by what made it thrive |
| 5. reconcile | _____ | E. to strip of its substance |

TRUE OR FALSE

Judge what the article states *or implies*. Circle T or F.

- | | | |
|--|----------|----------|
| 1. The protest had a built-in contradiction. | T | F |
| 2. Overtourism is mainly about numbers. | T | F |
| 3. Venice’s fee may be too small to work. | T | F |
| 4. The writer favors dispersing visitors. | T | F |
| 5. The article ultimately endorses reconciliation as the solution. | T | F |

DISCUSSION

- 1 Would you rather see a famous place packed with crowds, or not see it at all? Why?
- 2 Has a place you know been changed by outsiders? Who gained, who lost, and who decided?
- 3 Why do tourism’s profits and its costs so often land on different people?
- 4 Is Venice’s entry fee a sensible first step, or merely a symbolic gesture?
- 5 Should residents have the final say over their city’s future, even if visitors pay for it?



01 CRITICAL THINKING

YOU ARE THE COUNCIL

Your town has 40,000 residents and three million visitors a year.

Test the assumption behind each measure. Pass only what you can defend, then identify the weakest assumption.

MEASURE	ITS SUPPORTERS SAY	BUT IT ASSUMES	PASS
A tourist tax	"Visitors should pay for the damage they cause."	...the money will actually be spent repairing it.	☐
Cap the cruise ships	"Day-trippers bring crowds but spend little."	...those visitors won't simply arrive another way.	☐
Ban new hotels	"Fewer beds means fewer visitors."	...visitors won't just move into short-term rentals.	☐
Ban short-term tourist rentals	"Homes should house people, not tourists."	...owners won't simply sell or leave homes empty.	☐
Timed entry to the old town	"Spreading visitors out ends the overcrowding."	...a ticketed old town is still a living neighborhood.	☐
Change nothing	"The market will find its own balance."	...residents who leave can be replaced at no real cost.	☐

YOUR VOTE Measures passed: _____ of 6 The assumption your council is least sure of: _____

- DISCUSS**
- 1 Which measure you passed is most likely to backfire, and who would bear the brunt?
 - 2 Compare with another council. Challenge their weakest assumption, then defend yours.
 - 3 Which supporter's claim is worded most persuasively? Does the framing hide a weak assumption?

02 LANGUAGE IN CONTEXT

USE THE LANGUAGE

Complete each sentence with an expression from the box.
Change the form if you need to.

reconcile trade-off hollow out
a victim of its own success bear the brunt of

- 1 Every cap on visitors is a painful _____.
- 2 Local tenants usually _____ rising rents.
- 3 Once a secret, the cove became _____.
- 4 Can a city ever _____ the needs of residents and visitors?
- 5 Vacation rentals have _____ the old town.

04 WRITING

YOUR OPINION

"The cure for overtourism is worse than the disease." To what extent do you agree?

Write 200–250 words. Address the strongest opposing view before you answer it.

03 SPEAKING CHALLENGE

ROLE • PROPOSE • DEFEND

In small groups, build one position and hold it under pressure.

ROLE	You advise the mayor of a city that has become a victim of its own success.
PROPOSE	Recommend ONE policy. Say who will bear the brunt of it, and why that trade-off is worth making.
DEFEND	Present in two minutes. Another group then makes the strongest case against you. Answer it without abandoning your policy.